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The more the Hindutva arc widened, the deeper the anxiety around identity—of caste, class, community—grew. And every so often, their fury would burst, demanding justice or a fair share. The Dalit was wooed for his vote, but deep inside India's interiors, his lived reality remained much the same—from the institutional neglect that led to the suicide of research scholar Rohith Vemula in Hyderabad in January 2016 to the public flogging of a Dalit family in Una, Gujarat, the same year. So when the Supreme Court in 2018 passed an order widely seen as diluting the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, Dalit anger exploded, forcing the government to reverse the SC ruling.

Pushback to state excess unfolded even on the JNU campus in February 2016, when student leader Kanhaiya Kumar was slapped with sedition charges for his alleged anti-national speech at an event marking the death anniversary of Parliament attack convict Afzal Guru. Faculty, students and staff came together in protest against what they saw as a stifling of dissent.

The next frontier opened up in the winter of 2019, with the announcement of the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), which along with the National Register of Citizens (NRC) that had rolled out earlier in Assam, came to be seen as attempts to exclude one particular community. Shaheen Bagh, on the fringes of Delhi, became the symbolic heart of the anti-CAA protests of February 2020, even as Seelampur in Northeast Delhi turned into a site of a bloody communal riot.

Demand for quotas added another



Delhi: Who is to Blame
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"The writing had been on the wall—at least on the one-kilometre-long wall that separates the warren of *galis* from the sewage canal running through the Jafrabad area of northeast Delhi. Nineteen pieces of anti-CAA and anti-NRC graffiti were sprayed on that white façade. But the administration failed to see it. All it took was for someone to fling a stone, and the area erupted in a conflagration that lasted four days."



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